

CHAPTER 1

Mr Talwar's Uncertain Future

‘The best time to plant a tree was twenty years ago. The second best time is now.’

—ancient Chinese saying

An evening of celebration and reflection

Even by the standards of north India, it was an unusually hot June evening with the mercury hovering at 42 degrees Celsius. As is the norm during the evening rush hour, all roads leading away from Noida were gridlocked with bumper-to-bumper traffic. However, in flat number 901 of Aviral Housing Society, located just five minutes off the Delhi–Agra Expressway, the Talwar household was celebrating a special evening.

Yogesh Talwar beamed happily at the small gathering that had come together to celebrate his son's success in the Class XII Board exams. Ronit had scored 93 per cent and stood third in his class. It was time to celebrate as all the relatives commented on what a great future awaited Ronit. As immortalized in the classic 1967 movie *The Graduate*, relatives and family friends congratulated the young man and told him what they thought he should do with his life. Dustin Hoffman plays the graduate in this super hit movie that made him a star, earned him his first Oscar nomination and captured the spirit of that remarkable decade.

Mr Talwar felt a little uneasy about the happy predictions for his son. In the midst of the hubbub he could sense that something was not right, but he could not pinpoint the reasons for his disquiet. Once the guests were gone, he